

26th Annual Carolina Cup

October 2–4, 2026 • Columbia & Irmo, South Carolina

Welcome to our Carolina Cup guide. We put this together so everything about the weekend — travel, lodging, the venue, and what we're still waiting on from the tournament — lives in one place instead of scattered across emails and the group chat. As the tournament releases more information, we'll send updated versions of this same guide.

At a Glance

The one-minute version. If you read nothing else, read this.

Where	Complex not yet assigned Five SCUFC complexes • Columbia / Irmo, SC
When	Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026
Bracket	Under 09 Boys Red Division
Drive	~169 miles • ~3h 15min from Savannah
Hotel	Country Inn & Suites at Harbison — \$161/night Harbison cluster • cheapest confirmed
Do today	Book the hotel — hold a free-cancellation rate while you decide
Waiting on	Game schedule & field assignments (Sep 24)

1. Tournament Quick Start

Everything a busy parent needs, in under a minute.

Event	26th Annual Carolina Cup
Host	South Carolina United FC (SCUFC)
Team	Savannah United 17/18B Premier
Dates	Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026

Venue	Complex not yet assigned Five SCUFC complexes · Columbia / Irmo, SC
Age Group	U9 • 7v7 format
Bracket	Under 09 Boys Red Division
Format	Group play → knockout rounds
Entry Fee	\$725 per team for U8–U10 (7v7)
Check-in	Online check-in only. There is no on-site check-in.
Stay-to-Play	Not published — see Section 6
Drive	~169 miles • ~3h 15min via US-17 N → I-95 N → I-26 W
Parking	Free on-site at SCUFC complexes

2. Parent Action Items

DO THIS NOW

☐ Book your hotel

Re-checked live on September 18, 2026. Our top pick is now the Country Inn & Suites at Harbison at **\$161 per night**; the Hampton Inn Harbison did not come back as available and we have withdrawn it. See Section 6 for the full list.

ACTION REQUIRED

☐ Complete online check-in

The accepted team list posted on September 14 and Savannah United 17/18B Premier is confirmed on it. SCUFC states that online check-in is open and that teams should start it **immediately**. There is **no on-site check-in** at this event, so this cannot be handled at the field. Re-verified September 18, 2026.

BRACKET POSTED — SEPTEMBER 16

☐ Know who is in your bracket

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BEFORE LEAVING HOME

☐ Pack using the checklist

Section 12 has the full list. Early October in the Midlands swings from about 63°F in the morning to around 80°F in the afternoon — bring layers as well as heat gear.

BEFORE LEAVING HOME

□ Review the tournament rules

SCUFC has not published the 2026 rules document yet. Section 13 explains what we know and what we're still waiting on.

3. What We Know & What We're Waiting For

Confirmed

Official Tournament Information: 26th Annual Carolina Cup, October 2–4, 2026, hosted by South Carolina United FC in the Columbia/Irmo area of South Carolina.

Official Tournament Information: Open to boys and girls teams, U8 through U19, at Recreational, Intermediate, and Advanced levels. U8–U10 play 7v7.

Official Tournament Information: All teams must complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in.

Official Tournament Information: Tournament director is Tripp Miller (tripp@scufc.com). SCUFC phone: 877-457-2832.

Confirmed Team Information: Savannah United 17/18B Premier is accepted and scheduled to attend.

Pending Confirmation

Confirmed: Savannah United 17/18B Premier is on the official accepted team list (09U Boys). Online check-in is required — there is no on-site check-in.

Confirmed: our bracket is **Under 09 Boys Red Division** — 5 teams in total. Opponents in our division:

- CESA U9B Pre ECNL-RL Summit 1
- FC Revival U9 Boys Navy
- JIYSC U9 Boys Red Chambers
- SCUFC U9 Boys Blue

Verified at the source on the tournament site. The game-by-game pairings, kickoff times and fields are published with the full schedule on September 24, 2026.

Pending Confirmation: Game schedule and field assignments — posted September 24, 2026.

Pending Confirmation: Which of the five SCUFC complexes our team plays at, and the field within it.

Pending Confirmation: Whether a stay-to-play housing requirement applies. No policy has been published.

Pending Confirmation: The 2026 tournament rules document, including game length, mercy rule and tiebreakers.

Pending Confirmation: Coach instructions on arrival times, uniform and team-specific details.

4. Tournament Overview

The Carolina Cup is run by South Carolina United FC and is now in its 26th year. It draws teams from across the Southeast to five complexes across

the Columbia and Irmo area, and it has been one of the region's larger youth soccer weekends for a long time. Our U9 team will play 7v7.

Official Tournament Page (SincSports):
soccer.sincsports.com — [Carolina Cup](#)

Host Club:
southcarolinaunitedfc.com

Official Rules Document:
Not yet published for 2026

5. Travel & Arrival Planning

Drive from Savannah

Route: US-17 North → I-95 North (about 80 miles) → I-26 West (about 67 miles) → US-76 into Irmo.

Total: ~169 miles. Routing re-verified September 18, 2026 (168.9 mi / 3h 12min, free-flow).

Scenario	Time	Notes
Free-flow driving	~3h 15min	Routing engine, no stops
With a fuel and rest stop	~3h 35min	Add ~20 min
Friday evening traffic	~4h 00min	Add ~45 min

Why the first number is the real one: the free-flow figure of ~3h 15min is the routing calculation for the most direct route with no stops. The 3h 35min and 4h 00min figures are our own additions for a rest stop and for Friday evening traffic — they are planning buffers, not separate route measurements.

Player Report Time

Pending Confirmation. Game times are released September 24. Once we have them, we'll calculate each family's departure time so players arrive at the field **45 minutes before kickoff** for check-in, warm-up, and coach instructions.

Parent Manager Recommendation: An overnight stay avoids a pre-dawn Saturday drive. Two nights (Friday October 2 and Saturday October 3) is the pattern most traveling families use for this event.

6. Lodging

Housing requirement: SCUFC has not published a stay-to-play policy for the Carolina Cup. We checked the official tournament page, the host club site, and the registration portal, and found no stated hotel requirement or approved-hotel list. **Pending Confirmation** — we will confirm directly with the

tournament director (Tripp Miller, tripp@scufc.com) and update this section. Our recommendation is to book a cancellable rate now rather than wait.

Where to stay — re-checked September 18

Availability was re-run for October 2–4 (one room, two adults, one child) and the driving times were confirmed separately in Google Maps. Our previous first pick, the **Hampton Inn on Harbison Blvd**, **did not come back as available**, so we have withdrawn it. **Country Inn & Suites at Harbison is confirmed at \$161 per night** and is now our top pick.

Best options right now

Country Inn & Suites by Radisson, Columbia at Harbison — our pick

Rate: \$161 per night · \$322 for two nights
Distance to field: SE Freight 8.3 mi / ~13 min · Ballentine Park 9.8 mi / ~14 min (Google Maps) · Polo Road Park 17.2 mi / ~25 min · SV Presbyterian 18.7 mi / ~28 min

WoodSpring Suites Columbia – Irmo

Rate: \$189 per night · \$423 for two nights
Distance to field: SE Freight 6.7 mi / ~10 min (Google Maps) · Ballentine Park 12.2 mi / ~19 min · Polo Road Park 15.2 mi / ~22 min · SV Presbyterian 16.8 mi / ~25 min

Hilton Garden Inn Columbia/Harbison

Rate: \$273 per night · \$611 for two nights
Distance to field: Ballentine Park 5.7 mi / ~12 min (Google Maps) · SE Freight 10.3 mi / ~17 min · Polo Road Park 19.2 mi / ~29 min · SV Presbyterian 20.8 mi / ~31 min

MainStay Suites Columbia Harbison

Rate: \$279 per night · \$625 for two nights
Distance to field: Ballentine Park 5.6 mi / ~12 min (Google Maps) · SE Freight 10.3 mi / ~17 min · Polo Road Park 19.3 mi / ~29 min · SV Presbyterian 20.8 mi / ~32 min

Hyatt Place Columbia/Harbison

Rate: \$367 per night · \$821 for two nights
Distance to field: Ballentine Park 5.6 mi / ~12 min (Google Maps) · SE Freight 11.0 mi / ~17 min · Polo Road Park 19.9 mi / ~29 min · SV Presbyterian 21.4 mi / ~31 min

Why several distances? The Carolina Cup runs across five SCUFC complexes and the tournament does not assign our teams to one until the schedule posts on September 24. A hotel closest to Ballentine Park can be the furthest from Polo Road Park — so we show every complex rather than guess. Once each team's complex is known, that team's guide and app will lead with the hotel closest to *its* field.

Also available — further out

Comfort Suites Columbia at Harbison Ballentine Park 9.0 mi / ~12 min (Google Maps) • SE Freight 9.3 mi / ~15 min • Polo Road Park 18.2 mi / ~26 min • SV Presbyterian 19.7 mi / ~29 min	9.0 mi • ~12 min
LivSmart Studios by Hilton Columbia Greystone SE Freight 5.5 mi / ~11 min (Google Maps) • Polo Road Park 12.6 mi / ~20 min • Ballentine Park 13.8 mi / ~20 min • SV Presbyterian 14.2 mi / ~23 min	5.5 mi • ~11 min
Tru by Hilton Harbison Columbia Ballentine Park 6.2 mi / ~14 min (Google Maps) • SE Freight 9.8 mi / ~16 min • Polo Road Park 18.7 mi / ~27 min • SV Presbyterian 20.3 mi / ~30 min	6.2 mi • ~14 min
La Quinta Inn by Wyndham Columbia SE / Fort Jackson Polo Road Park 10.0 mi / ~14 min (Google Maps) • SE Freight 11.0 mi / ~21 min • SV Presbyterian 13.5 mi / ~20 min • Ballentine Park 21.9 mi / ~35 min	10.0 mi • ~14 min
SpringHill Suites by Marriott Camden being confirmed	Camden — allow 35–40 min
Leesville Lodge being confirmed	Lexington side
Motel 6 West Columbia – Airport being confirmed	West Columbia, near the airport

Important: Rates were pulled live on **September 18, 2026** from a Hotels.com search scoped to October 2–4 for one room, two adults and one child, and will change. This is a **partial result set, not full inventory** — a hotel not listed is unknown, not necessarily sold out. Driving times marked "Google Maps" were confirmed there on September 18; unmarked figures are router estimates awaiting the same check. Book a free-cancellation rate and re-check before you travel.

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SAVANNAH UNITED 17/18B PREMIER

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Where to stay — re-checked September 18

We re-ran availability for October 2–4 (one room, two adults, one child) and the picture has changed. Our previous first pick, the **Hampton Inn on Harbison Blvd**, **did not come back as available** in any search, so we have stopped recommending it. The **Country Inn & Suites at Harbison is confirmed at \$161 per night** and is now our top pick — cheaper than the Hampton we had been suggesting. The **Harbison** cluster (northwest Columbia, off I-26) is where the availability is; **Irmo** itself is closest to the complexes but nearly full.

Best options right now

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Country Inn & Suites by Radisson, Columbia at Harbison

Rate:	\$161 per night • \$322 for two nights
Area:	Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)
Notes:	Our pick — the cheapest confirmed Harbison room
Distance to field:	SE Freight 8.3 mi / ~13 min • Ballentine Park 9.8 mi / ~14 min (Google Maps) • Polo Road Park 17.2 mi / ~25 min • SV Presbyterian 18.7 mi / ~28 min

WoodSpring Suites Columbia – Irmo

Rate: \$189 per night • \$423 for two nights
Area: Irmo — the closest town to the complexes
Notes: Extended-stay style
SE Freight 6.3 mi / ~11 min • Ballentine
Distance to Park 12.2 mi / ~19 min • Polo Road Park
field: 15.2 mi / ~22 min • SV Presbyterian 16.8 mi
/ ~25 min

Hilton Garden Inn Columbia/Harbison

Rate: \$273 per night • \$611 for two nights
Area: Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)
Notes: Restaurant on site, pool
Ballentine Park 5.7 mi / ~12 min (Google
Distance to Maps) • SE Freight 10.3 mi / ~17 min • Polo
field: Road Park 19.2 mi / ~29 min • SV
Presbyterian 20.8 mi / ~31 min

MainStay Suites Columbia Harbison

Rate: \$279 per night • \$625 for two nights
Area: Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)
Notes: Suite-style with kitchenette
Ballentine Park 5.7 mi / ~11 min • SE
Distance to Freight 10.3 mi / ~17 min • Polo Road Park
field: 19.3 mi / ~29 min • SV Presbyterian 20.8
mi / ~32 min

Hyatt Place Columbia/Harbison

Rate: \$367 per night • \$821 for two nights
Area: Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)
Notes: Now cheaper than when we first checked
Ballentine Park 5.5 mi / ~10 min • SE
Distance to Freight 11.0 mi / ~17 min • Polo Road Park
field: 19.9 mi / ~29 min • SV Presbyterian 21.4 mi
/ ~31 min

Also available — further out

Comfort Suites Columbia at Harbison	\$308/nt • Harbison cluster
LivSmart Studios by Hilton Columbia Greystone	\$315/nt • Greystone
Tru by Hilton Harbison Columbia	\$319/nt • Harbison — not the Greystone property
La Quinta Inn by Wyndham Columbia SE / Fort Jackson	\$171/nt • SE Columbia, longer drive

SpringHill Suites by Marriott Camden	\$213/nt • Camden, allow 35–40 min
Leesville Lodge	\$194/nt • Lexington side, basic property
Motel 6 West Columbia – Airport	\$173/nt • budget option

Marriott Bonvoy eligible from this list: SpringHill Suites Camden. The Residence Inn and TownePlace Suites in Lexington did not come back as available, and neither did the Tru by Hilton Greystone or the Ramada Limited.

Important: These rates were pulled live on **September 18, 2026** from a Hotels.com search scoped to October 2–4 for one room, two adults and one child, and they will change. This is a **partial result set, not full inventory** — a hotel that does not appear here is unknown, not necessarily sold out. The two-night figures include taxes and fees. We have deliberately not published driving distances: the tournament has not yet assigned which of its five complexes our teams play at, and quoting a distance to the wrong one would be worse than quoting none. Book a free-cancellation rate and re-check before you travel.

7. Weather & Heat Planning

We are nearly three weeks out, so a daily forecast is not yet meaningful. What follows is what early October has actually looked like in Columbia over the past ten years, so families can plan clothing and hydration sensibly.

Typical early-October conditions in Columbia

Afternoon high	Around 80°F on average — has reached 95°F
Morning low	Around 63°F — noticeably cool at the first game
Rain	Roughly a 1-in-6 chance of measurable rain on any given day
Sun	Strong — open complexes with limited shade
Best games	Morning games are meaningfully cooler than afternoon

What this means for packing

This is a two-wardrobe weekend. Bring the heat gear — water, electrolytes, sunscreen, cooling towels — but also bring a jacket or warm layer for early mornings and a rain shell, because October in the Midlands is not August. Start hydrating the day before travel.

Based on ten years of recorded daily observations for Columbia, SC. **Check the actual forecast around September 28–30** for reliable day-by-day conditions. Source data: Open-Meteo historical archive (2016–2025).

8. Venue, Parking & Fields

Official Tournament Information: The Carolina Cup is played across five SCUFC complexes in the Columbia and Irmo area. Our team's specific complex and field will be assigned when the schedule is posted on September 24. Below are all five, so you can see where you might be going.

Ballentine Park Complex

1009 Bickley Road, Irmo, SC 29063

Listed as the tournament's primary venue on the event listing.

SCUFC West Soccer Complex

1053 Bird Road, Irmo, SC 29063

Polo Road Park

730 Polo Road, Columbia, SC 29229

Southeastern Freight Lines Soccer Center

115 Sunbelt Blvd, Columbia, SC 29203

SV Presbyterian Church Fields

125 Sparkleberry Lane, Columbia, SC 29229

Parking

Cost	Free — SCUFC complexes have on-site parking
Fill time	Fills early on tournament mornings
Fields	Grass; specific field layouts published per complex by SCUFC
Amenities	Concessions and restrooms at the complexes
Tent policy	Pending Confirmation — not published

Official field layouts (published by SCUFC):

[Ballentine Park field layout](#)

[SCUFC West field layout](#)

[Polo Road Park field layout](#)

[Southeastern Freight Lines field layout](#)

Parent Manager Recommendation: Arrive 30–45 minutes before your first game to secure parking and walk to your field. These are large, spread-out complexes.

9. Team Communication Plan

Official schedule	SincSports (Carolina Cup)
Team updates	PlayMetrics Messages • Email
Tournament logistics	Parent Manager
Soccer questions	Coach
Urgent changes	Team chat / text

An updated guide will be sent as soon as the schedule is released.

10. Coach Updates (Coming Soon)

This section will be updated once our coaches release arrival times, uniform details, and any team-specific instructions.

Parents do not need to act on these items — they are for reference once confirmed by the coaching staff.

11. Player Guidance

Tournament weekends are exciting and demanding for young players. A few practical reminders.

- Prioritize sleep — early bedtimes Friday and Saturday
- Keep meals familiar — not the weekend for new foods
- Bring simple, preferred snacks
- Encourage steady hydration through the day
- Limit exhausting hotel-pool activity before games
- Bring quiet activities for downtime between games
- Expect physical and emotional fatigue
- Keep postgame conversations positive and brief
- Let coaches handle the soccer instruction
- Emphasize effort, teamwork, learning, and fun

12. Packing Checklist

Player Gear

- ☐ Both uniform kits
- ☐ Cleats
- ☐ Shin guards
- ☐ Labeled water bottle
- ☐ Extra socks
- ☐ Warm-up / training gear
- ☐ Dry clothes
- ☐ Recovery shoes or sandals
- ☐ Personal medications
- ☐ Warm layer for early games

Weather & Hydration

- ☐ Water (plenty)
- ☐ Electrolytes
- ☐ Sunscreen (SPF 50+)
- ☐ Cooling towel
- ☐ Rain gear / shell
- ☐ Small fan
- ☐ Plastic bags for wet gear
- ☐ Extra blanket or jacket

Parent Sideline

- ☐ Folding chairs
- ☐ Umbrella
- ☐ Cooler
- ☐ Snacks
- ☐ Portable charger
- ☐ Wipes
- ☐ Trash bags
- ☐ Activities for siblings
- ☐ Cash for concessions
- ☐ Shade if permitted

Emergency

- ☐ Basic first-aid supplies
- ☐ Ice packs
- ☐ Insurance information
- ☐ Emergency contacts
- ☐ Prescriptions

13. Tournament Rules

Pending Confirmation

SCUFC has not published the 2026 Carolina Cup rules document. Game length, mercy rule, substitution rules, and the tiebreaker order are all still unconfirmed for this year.

We will not guess at these. As soon as the rules are published we'll add the full breakdown — including the complete tiebreaker hierarchy — to this section and resend the guide.

What we do know

Format	7v7 for U8–U10 age groups
Age groups	U8–U19, boys and girls
Levels	Recreational, Intermediate, Advanced
Sanctioning	US Youth Soccer affiliated (SC Youth Soccer)
Check-in	Online only — no on-site check-in

Rules questions: Tournament Director Tripp Miller — tripp@scufc.com

Bracket questions (U8–U12): Jamie McClendon — jamie@scufc.com

14. Nearby Family Resources

Distances measured from Ballentine Park Complex — the one listing sites name as the primary venue, but **only one of the five possible complexes**. Information current as of September 18, 2026.

Closest to the venue

CVS Pharmacy	0.3 mi
Food Lion	0.4 mi
Walmart Supercenter	1.1 mi • 1180 Dutch Fork Road
Publix	2.3 mi • 2732 North Lake Drive

Forgot something?

Dick's Sporting Goods	6.2 mi • 1110 Bower Parkway
Academy Sports + Outdoors	6.2 mi

Near the Harbison hotel cluster

Trader Joe's	275 Harbison Boulevard
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Publix	150 Harbison Boulevard
Rite Aid	5.1 mi from the venue

15. Weekend Itinerary

Friday, October 2

Travel day for most families. Leave Savannah by early afternoon — about 3h 15min in free-flow conditions and closer to 4 hours with traffic and a stop.

Saturday, October 3

Pending Confirmation. Schedule releases September 24. Player report time is 45 minutes before each kickoff.

Sunday, October 4

Pending Confirmation. Depends on Saturday's results. Plan checkout and departure around whether your team advances.

16. Quick Reference

Screenshot this for game day.

Tournament	26th Annual Carolina Cup
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Dates	Oct 2–4, 2026
Venue	Complex not yet assigned • five SCUFC complexes
Venue confirmed	With the schedule on Sep 24
Drive	~169 mi • ~3h 15min
Hotel	Country Inn & Suites Harbison • \$161/nt
Format	U9 • 7v7
Check-in	Online only — opens after Sep 14
Weather	~63°F morning / ~80°F afternoon • layers + heat gear
Director	Tripp Miller • tripp@scufc.com
SCUFC	877-457-2832

17. Final Next Steps

1. **Book your hotel now.** The Irmo area was 80% booked when we checked. A free-cancellation rate costs nothing to hold.
2. **Watch for the accepted team list on September 14,** then complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in at this tournament.
3. **Check the bracket September 16** and the **schedule September 24.** We'll send a refreshed guide with departure times once game times are live.
4. **Pack for two climates** — cool mornings, warm afternoons, and a real chance of rain.
5. **Check the forecast around September 28–30** for reliable day-by-day conditions.

Go, SU 17/18B Premier!

Looking forward to a great weekend in Columbia. Safe travels, and we'll send the updated guide as soon as the schedule drops.